

SARTHAK SINHA 12, Patna**Spends up to four hours on the computer everyday**

KRISHNA MURARI KISHAN

His father's personal laptop, which he has hijacked, is his best friend. "I like computer games; they are challenging," he says. His physical activities are almost non-existent. Though Sarthak likes football, he doesn't have much time for it. His father Rakesh, a senior executive with HDFC, is worried but says he cannot push him beyond a point. "It will breed rebellious tendencies in him."

49% children have access to the Internet at home or elsewhere. While 10% surfed the Internet in 2008, the number has gone up to 15% in 2009.

MEGHA GHOSH 15, Kolkata**Spends five hours on the computer everyday**

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Has 650 friends on Facebook though she is very "selective". She is on Wikipedia, F1.com, downloading songs and surfing youtube. She believes books are good for stories and computers for knowledge. She makes it a point to study till 2 a.m. Her mother says, "She is busy 18 hours a day. But as long as she knows what she is doing, I have no complaints."

ment. "I have come across young people who are on Facebook the whole night and then go to school and come back and sleep in the afternoon to keep up the whole night," says psychologist Shelja Sen. But psychiatrist Anurag Mishra says it is also perhaps the only way the child can exercise his free will. "When you have predetermined your child's goal and scheduled his daily existence between tuition classes and cricket coaching to achieve it in a competitive world, he will naturally gravitate towards something that allows him to indulge his own fantasies and dreams." Ayan Mukerji, a 25-year-old, who directed this generation's cult favourite, *Wake Up Sid*, echoes that, "I'm a great pop culture addict. It does make you more open to the world but I do know it can take over your life."

As in every generation, this rebellion is happening, albeit in a silent and stealthy way. Shiv Gautam, professor and head of the department of psychiatry, SMS Medical College and Hospital, Jaipur, quotes a 2006 study by his department based on 300 net users up to the age of 30, where they found 22 per cent of respondents up to the age of 17 spent more than eight hours a week on the Internet, driven by the liberty of online access, qualifying them for addictive behaviour. It is, as they say, a global phenomenon. In 2007, the American Academy of Paediatrics published a study which revealed that on a typical day, 75 per cent of children watched TV and 32 per cent watched videos and DVDs for an average of 80 minutes. Twenty-seven per cent of



five-six-year-olds used a computer for 50 minutes on an average, while 71 per cent of all in that age operated the mouse well. Startlingly, one-fifth of under-tuos and one-third of three-six-year-olds also had a TV in their bedrooms making it an isolated experience. A more recent survey by OfCom, an independent media regulator in the UK, showed that one-fifth of children in the age group five to seven accessed the Internet without adult supervision, one-tenth had a mobile phone and half had a television in their bedrooms. Eighty-five per cent had access to games console. Again, the percentage of children in the eight-11 age group who had access to the web in their own bedrooms increased from nine to 16 per cent in past two years, for age group 12 to 15, the increase was from 20 to 35 per cent. Sixty per cent of children in the age group of 12 to 15 and one-third in eight to 11 years said they have been accessing the web mostly on their own. Is that the future